

Word family: **hard / hardly / harden / hardness**

Base word: hard

Related forms: hardly, harden, hardness

Part of speech: adjective (形容詞) / adverb (副詞)

Your sentence:

> “What made it effective was that it did not try too **hard**.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **hard** is an **adverb**.

Meaning: With a great amount of effort. In this sentence, **try too hard** means making **more effort than necessary**, so that the result may start to feel forced, unnatural, or overly deliberate.

繁體中文: 過分用力或刻意地想達到某個效果，以致可能顯得不自然、太用力或太造作

中文翻譯:

「令它有效的原因，是它沒有過分刻意地想吸引或說服觀眾。」

try too hard = 過分努力／過分刻意，以致效果顯得不自然

1. **hard = effort** (做某事時投入大量努力) — 努力地; 用盡心力地

Here, **hard** is an **adverb**.

Meaning: With a lot of effort, energy, or determination.

Practice 1 — Original

> “What made it effective was that it did not try too **hard**.”

「令它有效的原因，是它沒有過分刻意地用力去達到效果。」

Practice 2

> “She studied **hard** for the exam.”

「她為考試非常努力地溫習。」

Practice 3

> “If you work **hard**, you’ll improve quickly.”

「如果你**努力**下功夫，你會進步得很快。」

hard = 做某事時投入大量努力或精力

2. **hard** = task/problem/subject (任務／問題／科目) difficult to do or understand — 困難的; 難以完成或理解的

Meaning: Requiring a lot of effort, skill, or thought because something is difficult.

Practice 4

> “This question is very **hard**.”

「這條問題**很難**理解或回答。」

Practice 5

> “Learning to speak naturally can be **hard**.”

「學會自然地說話可以是**很有難度**的。」

hard = 需要較多能力、思考或努力才能完成的

3. **hard** = material/surface (物料／表面) firm and not soft — 堅硬的; 不容易被壓下或改變形狀的

Meaning: Solid, firm, and difficult to press, bend, or cut.

Practice 6

> “The floor is very **hard**.”

「這個地板**很堅硬**，不容易被壓下或變形。」

Practice 7

> “This wood is too **hard** to cut easily.”

「這種木材**質地很硬, 不容易切割**。」

****hard = 質地堅硬、不容易被壓下或改變形狀****

4. ****hard = life/time/conditions (生活／時期／環境) severe and difficult to endure — 艱苦的; 難熬的****

****Meaning:** Involving difficulty, suffering, or unpleasant conditions over a period of time.**

Practice 8

> “The family went through ****hard**** times.”

「那個家庭經歷了一段****生活艱難、很難熬的時期****。」

Practice 9

> “It was a ****hard**** winter for older residents.”

「對年長居民來說, 那是一個****非常嚴酷難熬的冬天****。」

****hard = 環境或生活條件嚴峻、令人難以承受的****

5. ****hard = force/impact/weather (力量／撞擊／天氣) strong and intense — 強勁的; 猛烈的****

****Meaning:** Having a strong physical force or intensity.**

Practice 10

> “The ball hit the wall ****hard****.”

「球****猛烈地****撞向牆壁。」

Practice 11

> “It was raining ****hard**** all afternoon.”

「整個下午都下著****很猛烈的大雨****。」

****hard = 以很大的力量或強度發生****

Here, **hard** can be an adverb:

* **hit hard** = 猛烈撞擊

* **rain hard** = 雨勢很大

* **push hard** = 用很大力推

6. **hard** = person/attitude/approach (人／態度／處事方式) strict, tough, or unsympathetic — 嚴厲的; 強硬的

Meaning: Not gentle or lenient; demanding or uncompromising.

Practice 12

> “He is a **hard** boss who expects very high standards.”

「他是一位**要求非常嚴格、不容易通融的**上司。」

Practice 13

> “The government adopted a **hard** position during the negotiations.”

「政府在談判中採取了**強硬、不願輕易讓步的立場**。」

hard = 對人或事情採取嚴厲、強硬、不易讓步的態度

7. **hard** = evidence/facts/data (證據／事實／數據) clear, concrete, and reliable — 確實的; 具體可證實的

Meaning: Based on definite, measurable, or verifiable information rather than opinion or guesswork.

Practice 14

> “We need **hard** evidence before making an accusation.”

「在作出指控之前，我們需要**可以具體證實、可靠確切的證據**。」

Practice 15

> “The report contains very little **hard** data.”

「這份報告幾乎沒有**可量化、可驗證的實質數據**。」

****hard evidence/data = 具體、可靠並可以客觀驗證的證據／數據****

8. ****hard = alcohol(酒精飲品)strong and high in alcohol — 酒精濃度高的; 烈性的****

****Meaning:**** Used for strong alcoholic drinks, especially distilled spirits.

Practice 16

> “He rarely drinks ****hard**** liquor.”

「他很少喝****酒精濃度較高的烈酒****。」

Practice 17

> “The bar serves beer, wine, and ****hard**** spirits.”

「酒吧供應啤酒、葡萄酒和****高酒精濃度的烈酒****。」

****hard liquor = 酒精濃度高的烈酒****

9. ****hard copy(紙本文件) — 印在紙上的實體版本, 而不是電子版本****

****Meaning:**** A printed physical version of a document or file.

Practice 18

> “Please bring a ****hard copy**** of the report.”

「請帶一份報告的****紙本實體版本****。」

Practice 19

> “I prefer reading the document in ****hard copy****.”

「我比較喜歡閱讀文件的****紙本版本, 而不是電子版****。」

****hard copy = 印在紙上的實體文件版本****

This is an established modern use and should be learned as a whole expression.

10. **hard water**(水) — 含較多鈣、鎂等礦物質的水

Meaning: Water containing a relatively high concentration of dissolved minerals, especially calcium and magnesium.

Practice 20

> “This area has very **hard** water.”

「這個地區的水**含有較多鈣、鎂等礦物質**。」

Practice 21

> “**Hard** water can leave marks on bathroom surfaces.”

「**礦物質含量較高的硬水**可能會在浴室表面留下水垢。」

hard water = 含較高濃度鈣、鎂等礦物質的水

11. **hard c/g**(字母 c/g 的發音) — 發 /k/ 或 /g/ 音的

This is useful in language learning.

Meaning: A pronunciation of **c** or **g** using their /k/ or /g/ sound rather than their “soft” pronunciation.

Practice 22

> “The word ‘cat’ begins with a **hard c**.”

「cat 的 c 是**發 /k/ 音的硬音 c**。」

Practice 23

> “The g in ‘go’ is a **hard g**.”

「go 裡面的 g 是**發 /g/ 音的硬音 g**。」

hard c/g = c 或 g 發較硬的 /k/、/g/ 音

12. **hardly = almost not / only just — 幾乎不; 幾乎沒有**

This is a very important related form.

Hardly does NOT mean “努力地.”

Meaning: Almost not; only to a very small degree.

Practice 24

> “I could **hardly** hear him because the train was so noisy.”

「火車太嘈吵, 我**幾乎聽不到**他說話。」

Practice 25

> “There was **hardly** any space left.”

「那裡**幾乎沒有剩餘空間**。」

hardly = 幾乎不／幾乎沒有

Compare:

> “She works **hard**.”

> = 她**很努力工作**。

> “She **hardly** works.”

> = 她**幾乎不工作**。

These meanings are nearly opposite.

13. **harden = material/substance (物料／物質) become or make firm — 變硬; 使變硬**

Meaning: To become physically harder, or make something physically harder.

Practice 26

> “The paint will **harden** overnight.”

「油漆放一晚後會**變硬、凝固**。」

Practice 27

> “Heat can **harden** some materials.”

「高溫可以令某些物料**變得更硬**。」

harden = 使物質變得更堅硬／由軟變硬

14. **harden** = attitude/feelings (態度／感情) become less sympathetic or more severe — 變得冷硬; 變得更強硬

Meaning: To become less emotionally soft, sympathetic, or willing to compromise.

Practice 28

> “His attitude **hardened** after several failed negotiations.”

「幾次談判失敗後，他的態度**變得更強硬、不願讓步**。」

Practice 29

> “Years of conflict had **hardened** her.”

「多年的衝突令她**變得更冷硬、不容易受情感影響**。」

harden = 令態度或感情變得更強硬、冷淡或不易動搖

15. **hardness** = physical resistance to pressure/scratching (物料抵抗壓力／刮損的程度) — 硬度

Meaning: The degree to which a material resists being pressed, scratched, cut, or changed in shape.

Practice 30

> “Scientists tested the **hardness** of the material.”

「科學家測試了這種材料的**硬度**，即抵抗刮損或變形的程度。」

Practice 31

> “Diamond is known for its exceptional **hardness**.”

「鑽石以極高的**硬度**聞名。」

****hardness = 物料抵抗刮損、壓力或變形的程度****

Important distinction: **hard vs hardly**

This is one of the most important learner traps.

**hard**

= with a lot of effort

> “I studied ****hard****.”

「我****很努力地****溫習。」

**hardly**

= almost not

> “I ****hardly**** studied.”

「我****幾乎沒有****溫習。」

Adding ****-ly**** completely changes the meaning.

Important distinction: **hard vs difficult**

They overlap strongly when describing tasks.

> “The exam was ****hard****.”

> “The exam was ****difficult****.”

Both mean:

「考試****很有難度****。」

But ****hard**** has many additional meanings that ****difficult**** does not:

* **hard floor** = 堅硬的地板
 * **hard rain** = 猛烈的雨
 * **hard evidence** = 確實證據
 * **hard liquor** = 烈酒

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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try/work/study hard	做某事時投入大量努力或精力
hard task/problem	需要很多能力、思考或努力才能完成的
hard material/surface	質地堅硬、不容易被壓下或變形的
hard times/life	生活或環境條件嚴峻、令人難以承受的
hit/rain hard	以很大的力量或強度發生
hard person/position	態度嚴厲、強硬、不易讓步的
hard evidence/data	具體、可靠並可以客觀驗證的
hard liquor	酒精濃度高的烈酒
hard copy	印在紙上的實體文件版本
hard water	含較高濃度鈣、鎂等礦物質的水
hard c/g	c 或 g 發 /k/ 或 /g/ 的硬音
hardly	幾乎不／幾乎沒有
harden — material	使物質由軟變硬或更加堅硬
harden — attitude	令態度／感情變得更強硬或冷淡
hardness	物料抵抗刮損、壓力或變形的程度

For your original sentence

> “What made it effective was that it did not try too **hard**.”

The exact meaning is:

hard = 做某事時投入大量努力

But **too hard** adds the idea of excess:

try too hard = 過分用力或刻意地想達到某種效果，以致容易顯得不自然、太造作或太急於討好